Team Blue

Societal Problem Presentation

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Societal Problem

Students enrolled in the same course lack a convenient and consistent way to collaborate with classmates outside of class.

Problem Characteristics

Platforms such as Canvas are primarily designed for formal course discussions, while third-party platforms such as Discord, GroupMe, WhatsApp, and similar applications are often used for informal communication.

In a survey of 1,752 undergraduate students, 95.38% reported using student-created class messaging groups in at least some of their courses (le Roux & Parry, 2022).

This requires someone, if at all, to manually create and send out invitations, and sometimes requires students to create additional accounts to participate.

Who Benefits?

This platform could be useful for students who don't know others in the course, online students, or students who enroll late and may have missed the initial invitation.

Approach to addressing the problem

1. Link students to their enrolled courses using university sign-in and enrollment data.

2. Create a semester-based community for each course where classmates can ask questions, share resources, and organize study sessions.

3. Test with a few courses, gather feedback, and refine accessibility, privacy, and moderation before launch.

Solution

A web-based platform called Classes Together that automatically provides students with an informal, peer-focused community for each course they're currently enrolled in. Students would sign in using their existing university email, removing the need to create an account with another platform. Their current enrollment would automatically populate a dashboard that shows a list of semester-specific communities for each class. Access to each community would end when the semester is over, with optional ways for students to remain connected afterwards.

Software Platform/Style

Web application

- Accessible in a web browser on computers, tablets and phones without requiring an app to be downloaded

Simple interface

- A UI that shows your classes in a dashboard with each course having its own community

Access/Privacy

- University e-mail sign in (MIDAS sign in?)
- Enrollment based access

Tools and Technologies

Integrated Development Environment (IDE):

- VSCode

Version Control:

- Git, GitHub

Continuous Integration (CI) and Continuous Deployment (CD):

- GitHub Actions and Workflows

Selected Languages (Frontend):

- HTML
- CSS
- JavaScript

Database:

- PostgreSQL

Selected Languages (Backend):

- JavaScript (Node.js)

Testing Frameworks:

- Jest
- Playwright

Documentation Tool: JSDoc, Github README, and Wiki

References

le Roux, D. B., & Parry, D. A. (2022). An exploratory investigation of the use and effects of academic instant messaging groups among university students. *Education and Information Technologies*, *27*(1), 1055-1080. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10639-021-10631-y